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Submission to Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters (2025 Goldstein electorate)

OPENING COMMENTS: the problem
The conduct of two groups, Reveal the Teal & the [redacted] campaign, & their associates, stands out against a background of sustained aggressive, divisive conduct & a flood of misleading information directed most strongly against an [redacted] candidate, [redacted]. Her volunteers were also targeted. It happened in Kooyong too, though to a lesser extent. It is disturbing to hear [redacted] & the 3 leading Reveal the Teal women celebrating their groups' conduct & citing it as a model for future election 'success'. This has prompted me to make a submission.

The ongoing blindness to the social cost of their style of politics (& that of their shadowy associates) is disturbing. It created & exploited division, fear & anxiety in the already stressed Jewish community, & sadness in the broader community, at the ruthless focus on political gain. This exploitation of a vulnerable group, some of whom no longer feel at peace in this their home, together with the appalling treatment of [redacted], has left many with a 'moral injury'. She led with integrity, kindness & other respected core Australian values yet was mercilessly bullied/ demonised for political gain. There is a lingering sadness in the broader community at the loss of such an outstanding representative & especially at the poor behaviour used to attack her. Some report a loss of faith & trust in democratic process as well. This is such a serious issue

We must do better to protect candidates, perhaps by introducing workplace- style protections & obligations as they go about their duties. To prevent this Goldstein worst case scenario happening again, we need clear rules to prevent more harm to our community & to the democratic process itself.

1. THIRD PARTY GROUPS like Reveal the Teal were harsh & disruptive. Too many unjustly called [redacted] & some volunteers 'antisemitic'. This slur was usually accompanied by references to UNRWA delivery of supplies to Gazans. Traditional Australian pragmatic humanism (eg Weary Dunlop etc) was not just disrespected but demonised. In my opinion the handling of concerns around UNRWA contributed to the near hysteria of fear & paranoia whipped up in some already stressed Goldstein voters. The main source I heard of was a Reveal the Teal- related woman's presentation for the Australian Jewish Association called 'Does My [redacted] Support Terror.' This sensationalist approach made rational discussion near impossible. But there was probably more happening behind the scenes to further the politicisation of high anxiety, & exploit it. The [redacted] candidate's declaration that he was a Zionist was a surprise to many. So was the behaviour at the Brighton Synagogue. I was not present but keep hearing from reliable sources that the meeting was a stunt. [redacted] was apparently treated with kid gloves but [redacted] was yelled at & bullied although she was trying to find common ground while expressing traditional Australian pragmatic humanism. This has cut deep. I feel I am not represented by a politician of any party who would be associated with stirring up & benefitting from divisive tensions rather than working for peaceful coexistence. I am hurt that a candidate supporting direct, open conversation in order to deepen mutual understanding was badly mistreated. News of this unjust situation showed me I effectively do not have a representative at least until the next election. Melbourne Jewish friends have been startled by the strident extremism whipped up within their community. Activists have strained patience just as they need support. I have had apologies saying the extremist voices do not represent the majority in the Jewish community. The extreme, harsh voices have created tensions they lack the social skill to resolve. This must not be allowed to happen again.

WHAT REMEDIES ARE AVAILABLE?

It is hard to identify the behind the scenes connections between eg the [redacted] candidate & Reveal the Teal etc but there were glimpses of cooperation despite public declarations of working independently & without funding sources. WE NEED GREATER TRANSPARENCY so all voters can understand connections & agendas & make an informed choice of candidate.

1. FUNDING TRANSPARENCY - real time listing of donations with donors identified where amounts are large. [redacted] did this successfully. This will stop false claims eg [redacted] volunteers whispering to voters in my presence that [redacted] had 'a billionaire donating whereas we [redacted] campaign]' have so little..

2. AFFILIATIONS DECLARED TRANSPARENTLY Piecing together the broader picture isn't easy. My amateur reading suggests Reveal the Teal has links to J-United has links to Advance [formerly Advance Australia] supported by Mr Murdoch's Newscorp board member Tony Abbott (who claims donations/ bequests to Advance will protect Australian values although he is leaning Trumpwards). Advance's second largest donor is allegedly [redacted] husband. Did the Victorian [redacted] Cormack Foundation donate $500,000 to Advance as was reported? These hazy, often one- off comments about 'connections' (between elements of the [redacted] Party & Jewish community & doubtless linked to mining/ fossil fuel interests) must be assembled by near guesswork, making it harder to arrive at the truth. That creates tension which could be avoided if affiliations (& funding) were transparently declared. These tangled threads seem to call into question the Reveal the Teal claims that 'we built this from scratch'. It does not sound like the whole story. We need to avoid unnecessary confusion.

Clear information about political flyers matters. I received one set of [redacted] flyers- cheery bright blue, a smiling candidate & policies. I also received Reveal the Teal coloured flyers which were emotive- playing to fear. I threw a few out in disgust & decided to volunteer for the first time in my life.

It was only a few weeks ago that I noticed BOTH sorts of flyer were authorised by the same man- [redacted]. [redacted] The same address in Collins St. Looking up the address I saw it was Victoria's [redacted] Party headquarters. So [redacted] did not indicate [redacted] personal political preference. The Reveal the Teal style flyers were authorised by the [redacted] Party. I should not have to look this up. CLEAR, FULLY TRANSPARENT ATTRIBUTION is needed so even the most innocent of voters does not have to take time out of a busy day to pin down these details.

3. THIRD PARTY GROUPS To avoid confusion, & undue influence as witnessed in the recent election, third party groups like Reveal the Teal, Advance & others, should have no place in Australian elections. They chose to magnify attacks on targeted candidates either deliberately or through not realising the cumulative damage to the electoral process. At the very least third party groups should make clear their role & connections eg [redacted] party volunteers were seen changing into Reveal the Teal t shirts at one Goldstein polling place. Occult connections with third party groups should not allow the channeling of funds in ways that enable candidates to 'keep their hands clean'/ preserve deniability. They should not spread misinformation. Better they be banned from campaigns.

4. To avoid guesswork & misunderstanding, requirements to speak the TRUTH need to be reinforced. There needs to be a process for reporting false/ misleading claims/ cherrypicked & thus decontextualised statistics & assertions which interfere with voters understanding who/ what they are voting for. AEC might take on this role, with increased funding provided.

This 'truth in political discourse' requirement should extend to SOCIAL MEDIA trolls who misrepresent & harass targeted candidates (currently [redacted] politicians [redacted] & [redacted]). A Queensland friend told me to expect a surge from Queensland but would say no more. Trolls did pour in. The car/ motorbike/ boat/ dead fish profile pictures arrived, with claims to be from Queensland. They muddied the water with US populist style ad hominem attacks rather than thoughtful contributions. Who funded this apparently coordinated social media attack? Why has it continued against [redacted] & [redacted] after the election?

Some local people also trolled, sadly. When one group was finally banned from a tolerant politician's Facebook posts, I stumbled on them active on the Australian Jewish News, still misrepresenting the [redacted] candidate albeit more politely. I felt so sad. I still do. One was a former neighbour - at least she used her own (maiden) name.

Perhaps political posts should require a sign in & using their real name. With contact details to be used if they libel a target.

Finally, I am not sure what can be done about propagandists who use their role of 'reporter' to spread misinformation. I witnessed an interview in which the [redacted] candidate performed superbly in my professional opinion. Rebel News 'reporter' [redacted] praised her as the best (candidate?) he'd interviewed & expressed his respect but hoped she understood he could not write that. Instead he wrote a right wing cliche piece criticising her inability to define a woman etc. This misrepresented an able candidate & obstructed voters learning about her & her policies.

4. VOLUNTEER IDENTIFIER & CODE OF CONDUCT:

Conduct at polls was the worst I've witnessed. Similarly, a business owner complained to me of the aggressive conduct of [redacted] volunteers who entered her shop, told her to change her window display (an interesting blend of Chomsky etc, hardly controversial) & whose conduct intimidated & upset staff. I have seen another shopkeeper's hands tremble when discussing a related political issue. Finally a reliable source said another local Hampton Street business (since closed) was threatened by [redacted] volunteers. This needs to be confirmed/ investigated.

ALL VOLUNTEERS SHOULD BE IDENTIFIABLE BY A BADGE NUMBER (& first name?). Reports to campaigns which themselves model/ encourage inappropriate conduct clearly will not work. There needs to be an official (AEC?) to receive reports by volunteers.

I experienced 3 [redacted] volunteers who edged into my personal space, nearly hit my fliers out of my hands (twice), bumped into me while pushing through when there were better paths for them. [redacted] volunteers stood in front of [redacted] corflutes, made false funding claims to voters. One [redacted] woman ran -ran!- over to push 2 [redacted] volunteers out of the way (disrupting their helping an elderly couple out of the car), & took charge by walking the couple to the front of the line). The AEC did eventually stop [redacted] volunteers promising prioritised voting (but we needed a stronger AEC presence to stop various sorts of interference). [redacted] volunteers followed their candidate's example of acting divisively, putting an arm around a voter's shoulder or touching an arm, standing in their personal space, putting their face close to the voter's. Controlling street crossings in pairs to 'pick up' voters & talk so they passed other parties' flyers/ information. I heard the [redacted] candidate encourage that socially dominant conduct. The impact was claustrophobic & distracting, occurring as it did in a sea of blue shirts & corflutes- 60 corflutes in the short distance from North Rd to St Stephen's entrance path with 40 on the other side. This had the overwhelming impact of a casino. Elderly voters, especially, must have found it hard not to get swept up.

SO: volunteers to not make physical contact with voters or other volunteers. Maintain a reasonable distance (half a metre minimum, more if requested).

Reveal the Teal volunteers near me were loud & abrasive. As one Reveal the Teal leader stated, 'we had people walking up & down the lines [of voters] talking to people. We didn't just stand there. They were really engaging'. I saw two women standing still by the footpath while calling out false claims, reaching out across the footpath with flyers, overreaching in several ways. Because of their edgy, strident tone, they were worse than the too assertive [redacted] volunteers. They were disrespectful of the importance of the political process, seeming to be cynical & amused by their own antics.

VOLUNTEERS SHOULD NOT BE ALLOWED TO OBSTRUCT VOTERS' PATH. THEY SHOULD NOT PUSH FLYERS AGGRESSIVELY AT VOTERS. They should not heckle volunteers from other campaigns. AEC need more staff so they can monitor campaign conduct outside polling booths. It was hurtful to see our healthy democratic processes treated with such disrespect & a willingness to harm the processes & the community.

Lastly, some of the lads working for the [redacted] campaign & Reveal the Teal concerned me. They were too young to be exposed to behaviour which was distressing mature adults. One boy, up a tree to post a misleading Reveal the Teal poster, was shaking. Some students were play acting theatrically for a reporter. What have they been taught by the poor conduct of that campaign? WE NEED A MINIMUM AGE FOR VOLUNTEERS- 18? Maybe 21 is better.

HOW WILL WE GET DECENT, INTELLIGENT CANDIDATES OF GOOD MORAL CHARACTER PLUS INDIVIDUALS WILLING TO VOLUNTEER WITH CAMPAIGNS & VOTING IF THIS DAMAGING BEHAVIOUR IS NOT STOPPED NOW?

5. NO CAMPAIGN SHOULD BE INVOLVED IN ANY ASPECT OF DISTRIBUTING/ RECEIVING POSTAL VOTES. I received a postal vote in an envelope of material from the [redacted] campaign. I intended to use it but did not recognise the address on the envelope provided. Puzzled, I rang AEC to check the address was theirs. It was not. All she could say was 'this is legal'. THIS NEEDS TO BE REMEDIED. It was disappointing to know my information would be received by the [redacted] campaign - without my realising. This is SO inappropriate -& easy to fix.

6. EQUAL CANDIDATE ACCESS TO BUSINESSES SUCH AS AGED CARE HOMES. Neighbours spoke of their upset at having only a [redacted] visit relatives in care. Worse, one vulnerable relative had been frightened by claims that she had to vote [redacted] or her financial security would be at risk. ALL parties should have access

to voters, not just the preferred party of the business owner. Perhaps an observer is also needed.

7. While in Elsternwick [redacted] volunteers were approached by a man who seemed sincere. He warned that volunteers were unknowingly being subjected to electronic interaction. He said 'pinging.' By the [redacted] campaign ? Reveal the Teal? Maybe he was playing mind games but he did seem genuinely concerned. Members of the Jewish community did express embarrassment & concern for bad conduct against the [redacted] candidate. I pass this on without knowing its significance.

If we can persuade another kind, intelligent, ethical & courageous candidate to stand for Goldstein, I will volunteer again because I'm worried at what happened in 2025. We must stop the Reveal the Teal & recent [redacted] campaign's style of emotive flyers & misleading claims. Of intimidating anonymous letters & repeatedly destroyed [redacted] corflutes. A pocket of voters west of Jasper Road was too intimidated to put up corflutes- until we explained all but 3 we had spoken to were [redacted] supporters. This is unhealthy intimidation. Similarly some volunteers have said they could not face again some of the conduct (week one at St Stephen's North Brighton was traumatic I was told- I volunteered week 2 to fill the resultant gaps). It was so sad to be told several times that the [redacted] candidate was obviously the better option but could not be voted for because of fear- there was "an 'existential crisis' " this election.

Australia deserves to have voters making the right choice for their electorate, free of whipped up fears driving them in other directions. The impact of exploiting anxiety & fear over the positive values of hope & cooperation is a dangerous shift. Those cynically manipulating Goldstein (& to a lesser but still unacceptable degree, Kooyong) lack insight or else respect for core cultural values. We thus need rules in place to shore up our elections until the extreme & cynical gameplaying ends.